

# Agriculture Facts

## 2025

### Overview

According to the 2021 Census of Agriculture, Alberta has 41,505 farms covering 49.2 million acres, with an average farm size of 1,184 acres.

In 2024, agri-food industries **employed** 66,000 Albertans, with 36,200 in primary agriculture and 29,800 in food and beverage manufacturing industries.

Alberta agri-food **capital investment expenditures** in 2024 were \$3.5 billion, with \$2.7 billion in primary agriculture and \$794.5 million in food and beverage manufacturing.

Alberta's **gross domestic product (GDP)** in chained (2017) dollars for agri-food industries was \$9.8 billion, down 0.4 per cent from 2023 (\$9.9 billion). Of this total, agriculture industries accounted for \$5.3 billion, while food and beverage manufacturing was \$4.6 billion.

### Exports

The agri-food industry in Alberta is **export oriented**. The province accounted for 18.9 per cent of Canada's total agri-food exports (\$92.6 billion) and is the third largest exporter of agri-food products after Ontario and Saskatchewan. In 2024, Alberta's total agri-food exports was down 2.4 per cent to \$17.5 billion from 2023 (\$17.9 billion).

In 2024, **value-added exports** grew for the eleventh consecutive year to \$9.7 billion, up 0.2 per cent from 2023, representing 55.6 per cent of Alberta's total agri-food exports. Higher export values for pork, processed potatoes, refined canola oil, cereal preparations and processed meats, and other products contributed to the increase. Beef was the largest value-added export product at \$3.8 billion (down 3.3 per cent).

**Exports of primary commodities**, which represented 44.4 per cent of Alberta's total agri-food exports, fell from \$8.2 billion to \$7.8 billion, representing a 5.4 per cent decrease from 2023. The decline was largely driven by reduced export values for wheat, other oilseeds (largely soya beans), barley, canola seed and lentils. However, exports of live cattle (excluding purebred) and dry peas were notable increases.

The **United States** remained Alberta's largest export market (\$9.3 billion), accounting for 53 per cent of the total agri-food exports. China was the second largest at \$2.4 billion, followed by Japan (\$1.4 billion), Mexico (\$570.4 million) and

India (\$389.4 million). These five countries accounted for 80.4 per cent of Alberta's total agri-food exports.

The **top five Alberta agri-food exports** in 2024 (ranked by value) were beef (\$3.8 billion), wheat (\$2.8 billion), canola seed (\$1.7 billion), live cattle (excluding purebred) at \$1.4 billion, and crude canola oil (\$1.1 billion). These accounted for 61.9 per cent of total agri-food exports.

### Crop production

Alberta's total production of selected principal field crops, including forages, increased by 4 per cent to 30.3 million tonnes from 2023 (29.1 million tonnes). This growth was driven by higher production of crops including wheat, dry peas, lentils, chickpeas, dry beans, sugar beets, and forages.

In 2024, total wheat production in Alberta (9.9 million tonnes) represented 28.4 per cent of the Canadian total, while barley (4.2 million tonnes) accounted for 51.9 per cent. Canola (5.1 million tonnes) and oats (630,663 tonnes) represented 28.5 per cent and 18.8 per cent of the national total, respectively. Dry peas (1.2 million tonnes) accounted for 38.9 per cent of Canada's total. During the past decade (2014–2023), Alberta produced 31 per cent of the nation's wheat crop, 30 per cent of canola, 51.1 per cent of barley, 18.6 per cent of oats, and 42.8 per cent of dry peas.

### Livestock production

Alberta is the **largest cattle-producing province** in Canada, leading the nation in cattle and calf inventories, with an estimated 4.7 million head as of January 1, 2025, or 43 per cent of the national total (10.9 million head).

More than three-quarters of Canadian **beef processing** occurs in Western Canada, with the vast majority concentrated in Alberta. In 2024, Western Canadian cattle slaughter (excluding calves) in federally and provincially inspected plants was 2.5 million head or 78.6 per cent of the Canadian total (3.2 million head).

**Alberta beef production**, consisting of carcass and boxed beef, was an estimated 949,075 tonnes in 2024. Of this total, 13 per cent was consumed in the province. The majority was shipped out of province, with 53 per cent going to other provinces in Canada, 27.3 per cent exported to the United States and 6.7 per cent to other countries.

Alberta is also a significant producer of **pigs and sheep**. Among provinces, as of January 1, 2025, Alberta ranked third in sheep and lamb inventories (20.3 per cent of national total of 805,800 head) and fourth in hog inventories (11.1 per cent of national total of 13.9 million head).

Alberta continues to lead the nation in **honey production** at 15,119 tonnes, accounting for 42.6 per cent of the national total in 2024.

## Farm financial

In 2024, Alberta accounted for nearly one-quarter (23.6 per cent) of total **Canadian farm cash receipts** generated from primary agriculture and ranked first among provinces.

Alberta's **total farm cash receipts** were \$23.1 billion in 2024, down 0.9 per cent from 2023 (\$23.3 billion). Livestock market receipts accounted for 50.7 per cent of the total (\$11.7 billion), while crop market receipts accounted for 41.1 per cent (\$9.5 billion). Program payments fell to \$1.9 billion (down 10.9 per cent) from 2023 (\$2.1 billion) and were 8.1 per cent of the total.

**Alberta livestock and crop market receipts** in 2024 were a record \$21.2 billion. Of this total, cattle and calves accounted for 43.8 per cent, canola 17.5 per cent, and wheat (including durum) 14 per cent. Other contributions included 3.8 per cent for dairy, 2.6 per cent for barley, 2.6 per cent for hogs, and 15.7 per cent for all other commodities.

**The province's livestock market receipts** set a new industry high at \$11.7 billion in 2024, up 10.2 per cent from 2023 (\$10.6 billion) and ranked first among provinces. **Cattle and calf** market receipts set a record at \$9.3 billion, driven by record prices, and accounted for more than half (55.5 per cent) of the Canadian total. **Hog** market receipts totaled \$0.6 billion and represented 8.8 per cent of the national total.

In Alberta's supply management sector, **dairy producers** set a new industry high at \$0.8 billion in 2024, or 3.8 per cent of the province's total farm market receipts. Market receipts from the **poultry and egg industry** (including hatcheries) were \$0.7 billion, also a record, and 3.1 per cent of the provincial total market receipts.

**Crop market receipts** totaled \$9.5 billion in 2024, down 10.1 per cent from 2023 (\$10.6 billion), and were third highest crop market receipts on record. These accounted for 18.3 per cent of Canadian total and ranked third among provinces behind Saskatchewan and Ontario. The decline was primarily driven by lower prices for major crops. Notable declines in receipts were observed for dry peas (down 22.7 per cent), wheat (down 21.5 per cent), barley (down 19.7 per cent), canola (3.6 per cent), and oats (3.3 per cent).

At \$5.1 billion, **net cash income** for Alberta producers fell 9.2 per cent from 2023 (\$5.6 billion) and was third highest net cash income on record. Similarly, realized net income dropped 15.5 per cent to \$2.7 billion, also the third highest realized net income. Total net income declined 40.6 per cent to \$1.8 billion, due to a negative value of inventory change, and was sixth highest total net income on record. Among provinces, Alberta ranked second to Saskatchewan in net cash income, realized net income, and total net income.

Producers spent a record \$18 billion in **farm operating expenses** (after rebates) in 2024, up 1.7 per cent from 2023 (\$17.7 billion). Notable increases in expenses were livestock and poultry purchases (up 17.6 per cent), interest payments (up 29.4 per cent), machinery fuel and repairs (up 1.8 per cent), and commercial seed (up 0.8 per cent). Conversely, there were notable declines including commercial feed (down 12.4 per cent, fertilizer and lime (down 7.1 per cent), cash wages, room and board (down 1 per cent), and electricity (down 24.9 per cent).

On July 1, 2024, **total farm capital** in Alberta was valued at a record \$230.6 billion, up 8.2 per cent from 2023 (\$213.1 billion). This consisted of \$196.3 billion in land and buildings, \$20 billion in machinery and equipment and \$14.3 billion in livestock and poultry.

## Food manufacturing and retail sales

**Food manufacturing** sales continued an upward trend in 2024, reaching a record \$24.3 billion. Food manufacturing was the second largest industry in the province (23.5 per cent of provincial manufacturing sales), behind petroleum and coal product manufacturing (25.9 per cent).

**Meat product manufacturing** accounted for more than half of food manufacturing in the province. In 2024, sales of meat products, including poultry, totaled \$13.1 billion (54.1 per cent of total food manufacturing sales).

**Retail sales** for food and beverage stores were \$17.5 billion in 2024, up 0.9 per cent from 2023 (\$17.4 billion). Sales for grocery and convenience stores rose 1 per cent to \$13.4 billion, while sales for beer, wine and liquor stores fell slightly by 0.1 per cent to \$3 billion. Specialty food store sales increased 1.8 per cent to \$1.1 billion. Receipts for food services and drinking establishments increased 2.9 per cent to \$12.3 billion.

## For more information, contact

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